Longpi Hamlei Black Stone Pottery

Resource Identifier: CULT-TRAD-005

English Translation: Indigenous Handcrafted Black Serpentinite Pottery

Category: Tradition | Subcategory: Craft

Village / Region: Longpi | Dialect: Longpi / Loree

Contributor / Source: Longpi (Loree) Master Potters (Traditional Craft (Hodson 1911, TRI Manipur))

License: Traditional Cultural Expression (Permissions: community_authorized)

Seasonal Timing / Occasion: Dry winter months (Exclusively Longpi village)

Ethnographic Summary & Context:

Renowned ancient pottery crafted without a potter’s wheel using ground black serpentinite rock (leshong lung) and weathered clay (sali), fired outdoors and polished with Chiron/Mahasa leaves.

Indigenous Tangkhul Text / Chants / Sayings:

"Longpi Loree Hamlei kashak avava apuipui wui pangthei."
"Leshong lung kala sali ngarumda, wheel makhavai pangna sai."
"Mahasa thingron aina phatsangda, kakhangaza black stone ham."

English Translation & Meaning:

"Longpi Loree pottery embodies the ancient, unmatched craftsmanship of our ancestors."
"Blending crushed black serpentinite stone with mountain clay, shaped entirely by hand without a wheel."
"Polished with Mahasa leaves while hot from the bonfire kiln, producing lustrous black stoneware."

Procedural Sequence / Observance Steps:

1. Mining serpentinite rock (leshong lung) and weathering clay (sali) from sacred local sites.
2. Crushing and grinding the stone into fine powder on stone mortars.
3. Kneading stone powder and clay in equal proportion with mountain water into stiff paste.
4. Hand-coiling and paddle-shaping vessels into pots (Ham), kettles, and platters without a wheel.
5. Bonfire open firing and hot-burnishing with fresh Chiron/Mahasa leaves to achieve deep metallic black luster.

Ceremonial Participants & Roles:

Longpi Master Potters (Men and Women), Village Apprentices